Thorat's papers. He first read the paragraphs indicated to him by Thorat, after which he went through the folder outlining the details of Exercise Lal Qila.

After twenty minutes or so, Nehru asked why the files had not been shown to him previously.

'You may like to address this question to Mister Krishna Menon, sir,' said Thorat, with ill-concealed sarcasm.

'Menon! Menon!' exploded Nehru. 'Why have you got your knife into him? You people do not realize what an intellectual giant he is!' Even at this stage, with the Chinese threatening to spill into the Brahmaputra Plains, Nehru was not willing to listen to any criticism of his former defence minister. Sitting in front of him was the man who would have been the chief if it hadn't been for the political machinations of the defence minister and Nehru himself. Menon had time and again refused to listen to the warnings of both Thimayya and Thorat. Nehru then asked Thorat if the Chinese would take the Brahmaputra Valley. Thorat replied candidly that he didn't think so; in his opinion, they had already penetrated further than they should have. Thorat further elaborated that owing to the mountainous terrain and lack of roads they were not able to bring up any heavy weapons such as tanks and artillery and it was highly unlikely that they would want to stretch their lines of communication that far. All that Nehru could say was: 'I hope so! I hope so!'

There being nothing more to be said, Thorat took his leave and left the office. Nehru barely noticed that the general had left the room.

At 10.30 a.m. there was an operational briefing by the MO directorate. At the last minute the prime minister decided to go to Parliament instead, taking H. C. Sarin with him. Among those present at the meeting were the COAS General Thapar, the newly appointed CGS, Lieutenant General Moti Sagar, the Western Army Commander, Lieutenant General Daulet Singh and his chief of staff, Major General Joginder Singh, and Lieutenant General K. Wadalia. The DMO quickly summarized the various events that had led to the collapse of 4 Infantry Division during the previous forty-eight hours. He then moved on to the immediate problem at hand: the defence of Assam. Even as Palit spoke, IAF AN-12 and Fairchild Packets had started to land in Tezpur with 5 Infantry Division. Air HQ had indicated that the airlift would be completed by last light on 20 November. Though 5 Division was without artillery support, heavy weapons or vehicles, it was better equipped than